

Teaching Innovation: Three Rounds

A Structured Exercise for Teaching AI Literacy Through Writing

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The Problem

Generative AI has made student artifacts unreliable as signals of learning. A polished deck, a well-structured paper, or a fluent analysis can now be produced in minutes with minimal student thinking. Traditional assessment methods (rubrics applied to submitted work) cannot distinguish between a student who used AI to sharpen their own ideas and a student who outsourced the thinking entirely. The gap is not between good and bad students. It is between students using AI as a thinking partner and students using AI as an answer generator.

The Innovation: Three Rounds

Three Rounds is a structured writing exercise that makes the student's thinking process visible by running the same assignment through three distinct conditions. The exercise is delivered as a system-level prompt pasted into any AI tool (Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini). The AI enforces the structure, holds boundaries between rounds, and facilitates the final reflection.

	Round 1: Solo Draft	Round 2: AI as Thinking Partner	Round 3: AI Drafts, Student Critiques
Who writes	Student writes alone. AI receives the draft without editing or suggesting changes.	Student writes. AI asks questions, surfaces assumptions, identifies gaps. AI cannot draft, rewrite, or generate content.	AI generates a complete, confident draft. Student critiques it: what's true, what's hollow, what their own version gets right.
Purpose	Establishes baseline: what the student thinks before AI touches the problem.	Develops thinking without replacing it. Student revises based on AI-prompted reflection.	Exposes what AI-generated work looks like and whether the student can distinguish substance from fluency.
Key signal	Raw thinking. Starting position. Assumptions visible.	What shifted in the student's reasoning and what remained unchanged.	Can the student identify where AI sounds confident but lacks substance?

Structured Reflection

After all three rounds, the AI guides the student through five reflection questions, delivered one at a time:

- What did Round 1 expose about your starting position?
- What did Round 2 change in your thinking — and what didn't change?
- What did Round 3 reveal about how AI handles this kind of problem?
- Where did the AI's instincts differ from yours, and who was right?
- If you had to submit one version, which would it be, and why?

Pedagogical Foundation

Three Rounds addresses three gaps in current AI pedagogy simultaneously:

- **Visibility.** AI use becomes explicit and structured rather than hidden and unexamined. Students document what AI contributed and what they contributed.

- **Metacognition.** The three-condition design forces students to observe their own thinking process across different modes. The reflection is the assessment, not the artifact.
- **Critical evaluation.** Round 3 specifically trains students to critique AI-generated output, distinguishing confident fluency from genuine substance. This is the core skill of AI literacy.

Implementation

Element	Details
Time required	Teachable in a single class session. Students complete the exercise asynchronously with AI enforcing the structure.
Tools	Any generative AI tool (Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini). The full prompt is open source and available in the companion article.
Prerequisites	None. No coding, no AI experience required. The prompt handles all structure and boundary enforcement.
Disciplines	Designed for business courses. Adaptable to any discipline involving analytical or persuasive writing.
Assessment	The reflection (not the artifact) is the graded output. Can be paired with a 10-minute live defense for deeper signal.

Preliminary Observations

- Students consistently report that Round 2 (AI as thinking partner) produced their strongest work, but that Round 1 (solo) contained their most original ideas.
- Round 3 reliably exposes the difference between fluency and substance. Students who struggled to critique the AI draft showed the weakest critical thinking across all three rounds.
- The exercise reframes AI from a cheating risk to a learning tool. Students who completed Three Rounds reported more intentional and reflective AI use in subsequent assignments.
- The structured prompt eliminates the need for faculty to police AI use. The exercise makes the use visible by design.

"The point isn't to prove that AI is good or bad at writing. It's to make the student's own thinking process visible by running it through three different conditions. By the end, students can articulate exactly what AI adds, what it takes away, and where their own judgment made the difference. That's AI literacy. And it's teachable in a single class session."

Full prompt, companion article, and open-source materials: medium.com/@john-andrews

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